



The Selectboard
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

MINUTES of the MEETING

Monday, June 17, 2024, at 7:00 PM

The Westhampton Selectboard scheduled a regular meeting on Monday, June 17, 2024, at 7:00 PM at the Town Offices, 1 South Road.

Call to Order

The meeting was called to order at 7:02 PM by Mr. Scott Johndrow.

Present: Scott Johndrow, Susan Bronstein, Jennifer Milikowsky

Others Present: Douglas Finn; others as noted.

ADA Grievance Procedure

A third and final reading of the draft ADA Grievance Procedure was reviewed.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Bronstein

To approve the Grievance Procedure as presented and amended.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (7:11 PM)

Presentation / Update – P27 Offroad

Paul Goyette, from P27 Off Road, was present to discuss details of the upcoming event to be held on the Desantis property (Assessors Parcel 29-9), adjacent to 360 Main Road.

Details of the event

Mr. Goyette noted that some recent items had been addressed:

- EMS – Bailey Jones (Hilltown Ambulance) will be on site with an ambulance.
- SANITARY – White Wolf septic will be providing porta-potty service
- INSURANCE - Joan Birdsong Insurance will provide a policy
- FOOD SERVICE – Barney’s Barbeque will be providing food; food service approval is still pending. Mr. Finn will reach out to the Board of Health and FHD.
- SECURITY – the site will be made secure using staff security.

Chief David Antosz was present, and after review, had no questions or concerns.

There were no other questions from the board, and they wished Mr. Goyette and his team success with the event.

Department Reports

Highway

Bill Jablonski noted the following recent work:

- Chipsealing several roads in the Town, including Mine Road, Turkey Hill, and others;
- Staff had been spending vacation time;
- Chris Alexander's work coop was completed, and was successful.
- Some shop work included maintenance of equipment.
- Grading of dirt roads.
- Septic System location was laid out at the library
- Repairs to the culvert bridge south of the high school.

Mr. Jablonski noted that Mr. Andrew Nichols had submitted his resignation from the Transfer Station. His late date will be August 21. The board agreed that Mr. Jablonski will work with Mr. Finn to post the job, and screen potential candidates prior to final interview and appointment by the board.

Ms. Milikowsky asked about staff management in the anticipated heat. Mr. Jablonski noted that the crew will be taking necessary precautions to stay hydrated and moderate their activity.

Others as may be present

Chief David Antosz led a discussion relative to

Administrative Business

Special Town Meeting

Mr. Finn presented a draft of the proposed motions for the special town meeting, to be held on Monday, June 24, 2024, 7 PM. There was discussion about the topics.

Cable Franchise Negotiations

Mr Finn noted that the process of renegotiation of the cable franchise requires a public hearing, and recommended that the hearing be held on July 15, 2024, 7 PM. Board agreed.

Mr. Finn noted that outstanding matters subject to negotiation include 'last ½ mile' connection of certain roads and homes in Westhampton, including the north end of Tob Hill Road, and certain portions of Laural Hill Road. A potential agreement with Northampton Open Media is also in the works, which may provide PEG Access to Westhampton, including the ability for Westhampton residents to see all NOM cablecasts, receive training, use equipment, and submit programs for airing on NOM channels in Northampton and Westhampton.

Digital Equity Planning, including "BEAD" challenges

Mr. Finn noted that the Broadband Equity Access and Deployment ("BEAD") process was ongoing and would hopefully result in a clear picture of those homes and areas in Westhampton that remain without connection to high-speed internet.

Mr. Finn noted a public listening session would be held at the Town Hall on June 27, 6:30 PM, to present the draft Digital Equity Plan, and to hear comments from residents and businesses in regard to the plan, and high-speed internet access in general.

Mr. Finn also noted that the broadband committee had just started to consider the potential for a municipal light plant, which could potentially seek out grants to build a town-owned fiber-optic network. This network could give options to residents for significantly higher speed internet access at a lower cost than Comcast. However, discussions were just at the opening stages, with new information anticipated in the coming weeks.

Accounting Software

Mr. Finn noted that the town's physical server had aged beyond its useful life; however, the cost for replacement of the server would be significant. As the only software running on the server was the town's accounting package, Ms. Patty Cotton had reached out to Springbrook, the company that manages the Town's accounting software, for options for remote hosting of the software on Springbrook's servers. While the costs for hosting would add roughly \$4,000 per year to the current software costs, the advantages would include reduced maintenance costs, increased security of the town's fiscal information, reliability and redundancy, and increased security of the town's computer network. Discussions between Springbrook, the Treasurer, Tax Collector and Accountant were ongoing, and a recommendation would be forthcoming.

Review Correspondence

A letter from Charlene Cross was reviewed. No action taken.

Review and Sign: Payroll and A/P Warrants: W24-26, WP24-26

Accounts Payable and Payroll Warrants were reviewed. After review, it was MOVED by Bronstein, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve Warrants W24-26 and WP24-26 as presented.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0 (8:15 PM)

Review and Sign: Minutes from Previous Meetings

The minutes of June 3, 2024 were reviewed. After review, it was MOVED by Bronstein SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve the minutes of June 3, 2024 as presented.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0 (8:25 PM)

End of Year Transfers

The board considered two end of year transfers as follows:
It was MOVED yb Johndrow, SECONDED by Bronstein –

To approve as presented.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0 (8:28 PM)

Upcoming Events:

Next Meetings: July 1, July 15, 7 PM
Special Town Meeting: June 24, 2024, 7 PM

Executive Session – if needed or requested

Mr. Finn noted that minutes from the Executive Session were available for review / approval, and requested an executive summary

Executive Session – if needed or requested

Mr. Finn requested an executive session to review and approve minutes of previous

executive sessions, and to discuss a personnel matter related to potential litigation.
It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Bronstein

To enter into executive session for the reasons as requested, and thereafter to adjourn.

VOTED: BRONSTEIN: YES; MILIKOWSKY: YES; JOHNDROW: YES (8:29 PM)

EXECUTIVE SESSION

Adjournment

There being no further business, it was MOVED by Bronstein, SECONDED by Johndrow

To exit executive session, and thereafter to adjourn.

VOTED: BRONSTEIN: YES; MILIKOWSKY: YES; JOHNDROW: YES (8:54 PM)

Respectfully submitted,
Douglas C. Finn

Approved by a vote of the Selectboard at a regular meeting, held on July 1, 2024.

Scott Johndrow

Susan Bronstein

Jennifer Milikowsky